



YOUTH AND ADOLESCENT SEXUAL DEVELOPMENT

NURS 280 JUNE 4, 2026



ADOLESCENT SEXUAL DEVELOPMENT

- Often, first romantic/sexual relationships
- Masturbation common (more so for folks with penises: 80% vs. 58%)

Young people this age are learning:

- how to adapt to their changing bodies
- how to protect their sexual health

Young people this age are developing:

- their sexual selves (needs, feelings, desires, identity, etc.)
- relationship skills (healthy & unhealthy)



REPRESENTATION OF ADOLESCENT SEXUALITY IN MEDIA SEX EDUCATION (NETFLIX)



SEXUAL DEBUT

- Many overestimate their peers' sexual experience: 90% of students surveyed thought they had had fewer sexual partners than their peers (Stephenson 2009)
- 84% of BC students have not engaged in intercourse (AHS 2023)
- 17 is the average age of sexual debut in Canada **for those who reported being sexually active** (Tsui 2004)
- Most (80%) were in a romantic relationship with their partner during sexual debut (Reissing)
- Poor school attachment and poor parental relationships are strongly predictive of early sexual debut (Boyce 2003)



GENDER	PHYSICALLY SATISFYING	EMOTIONALLY SATISFYING
Cis female	35%	54%
Cis male	62%	42%

O'Sullivan 2008



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@DrSprankle

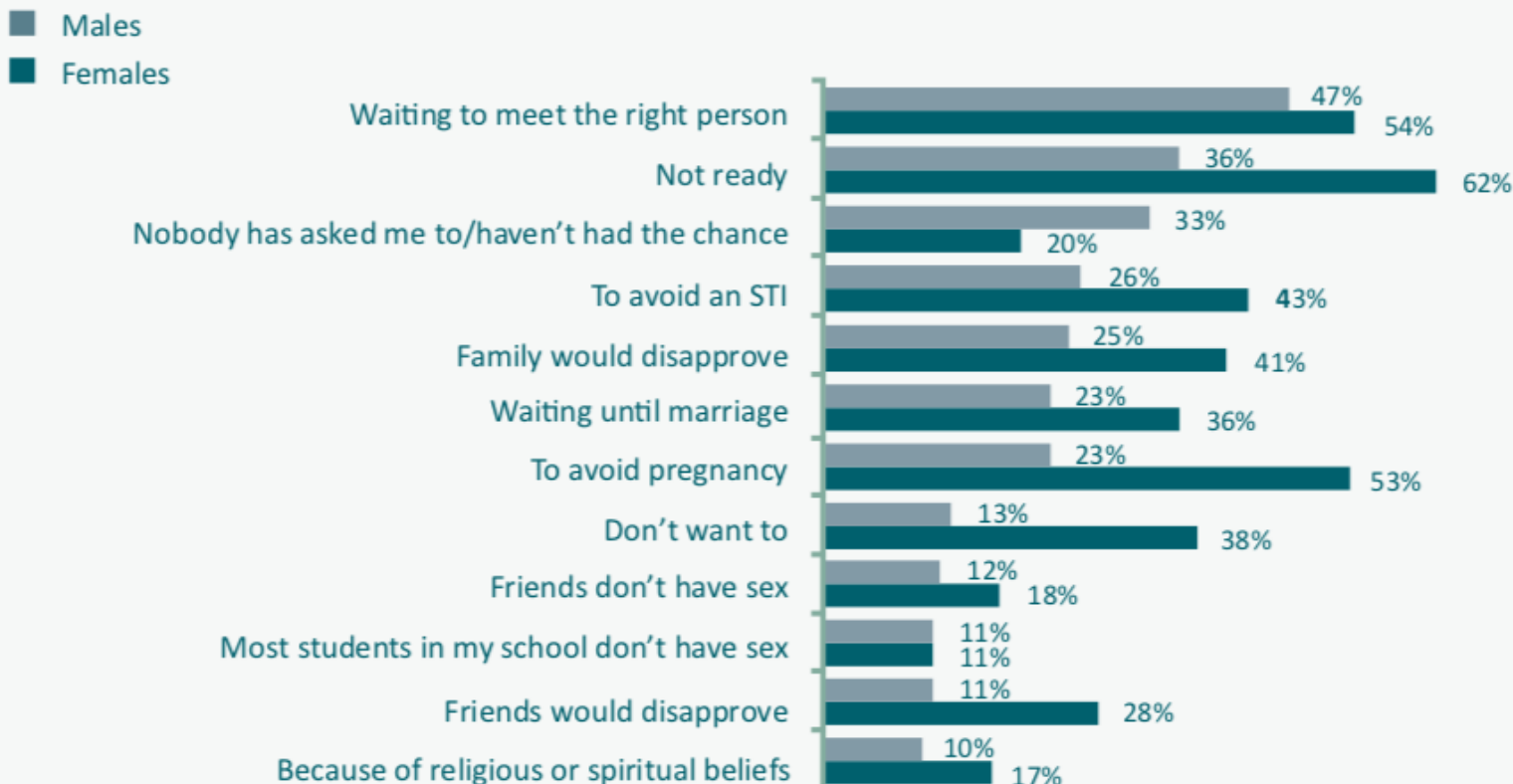
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Chastity isn't more virtuous than promiscuity. What's virtuous is having insight into your sexual needs and values, and engaging in consensual behavior that is congruent with those needs and values.

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REASONS FOR NOT HAVING INTERCOURSE (AMONG YOUTH WHO HAD NEVER HAD INTERCOURSE)



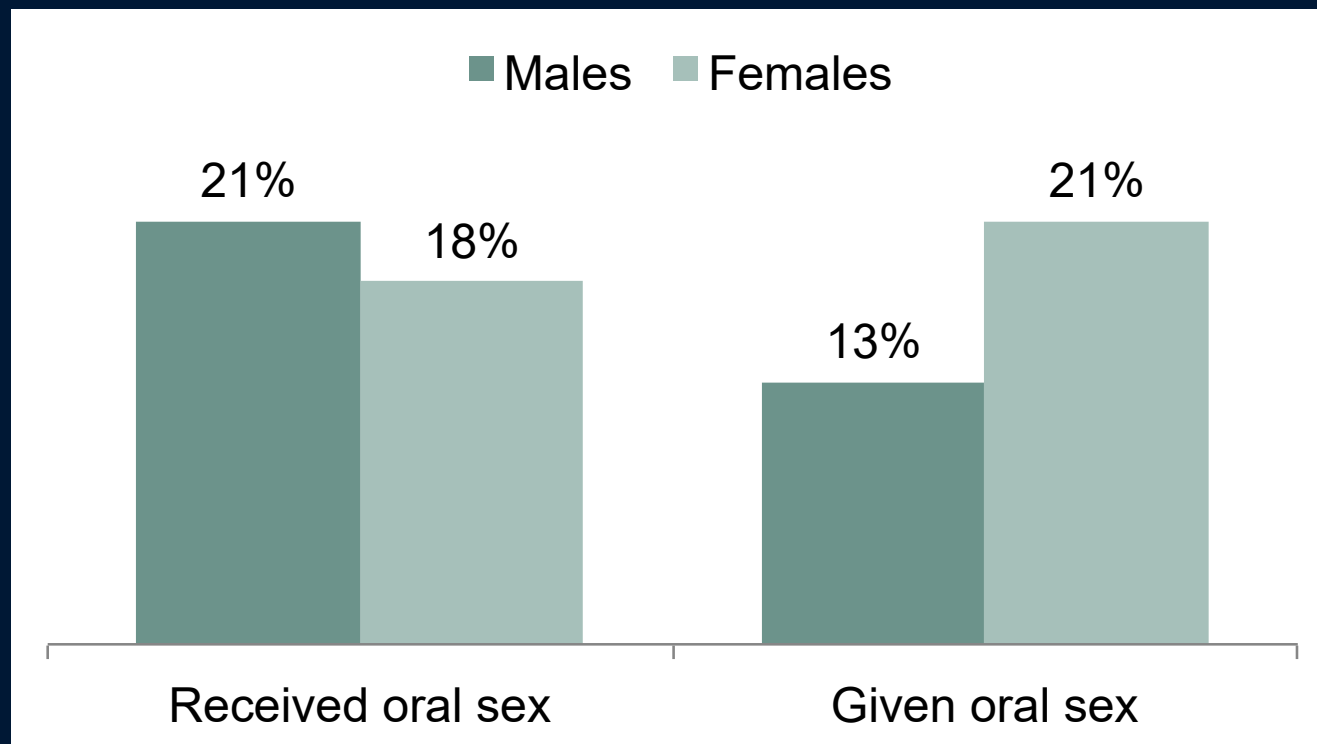
SOURCE 2008 BC AHS.

NOTE Youth could choose more than one response.



ORAL SEX

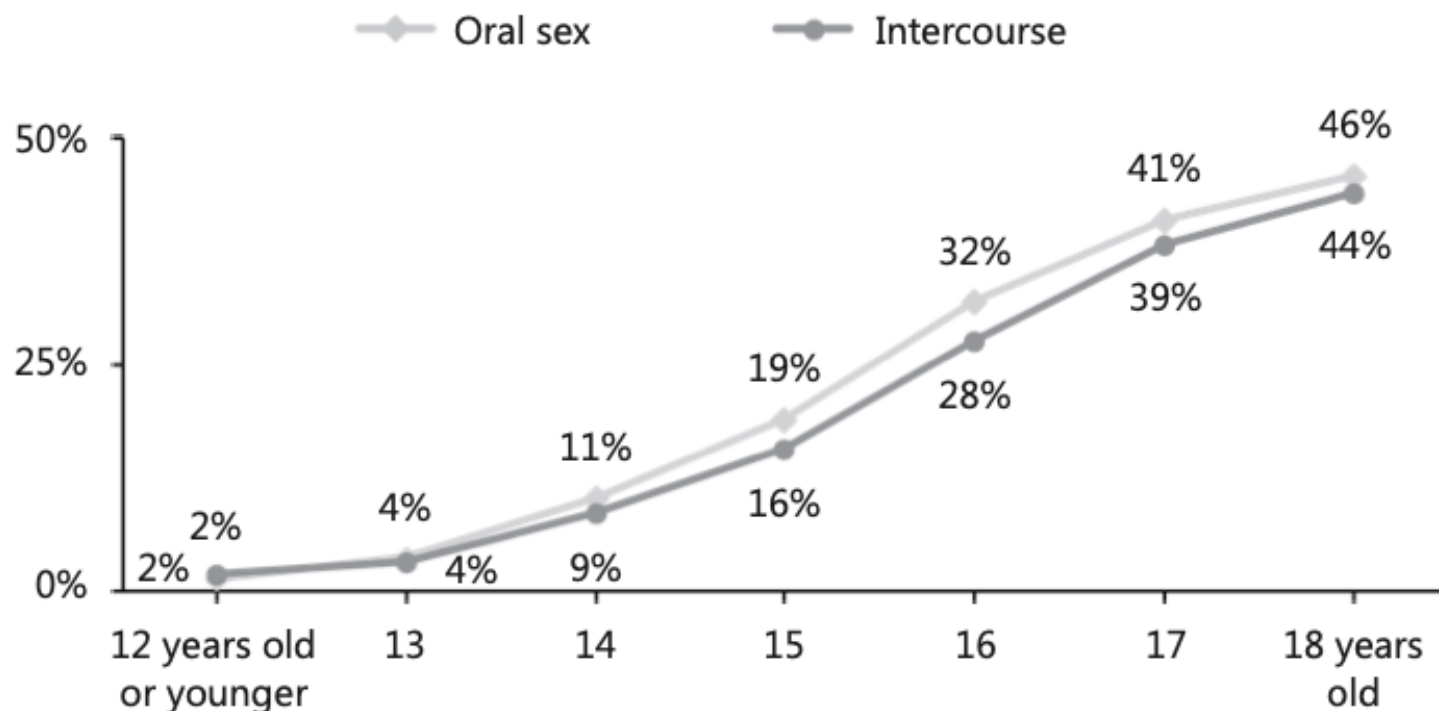
- about as common as intercourse and often first occurs around the same age (Lindberg 2008)
- in BC 17% of students had ever had oral sex—down from 26% in 2008 (AHS 2023)



EVER ENGAGED IN SEXUAL ACTIVITY (AHS 2018)



Ever engaged in sexual activity



Note: The difference in rates between ever having oral sex and ever having intercourse were not statistically significant for 17- and 18-year-olds.

EFFORTS TO PREVENT PREGNANCY (AHS 2008 – 2023))

Note: Youth could mark all that applied

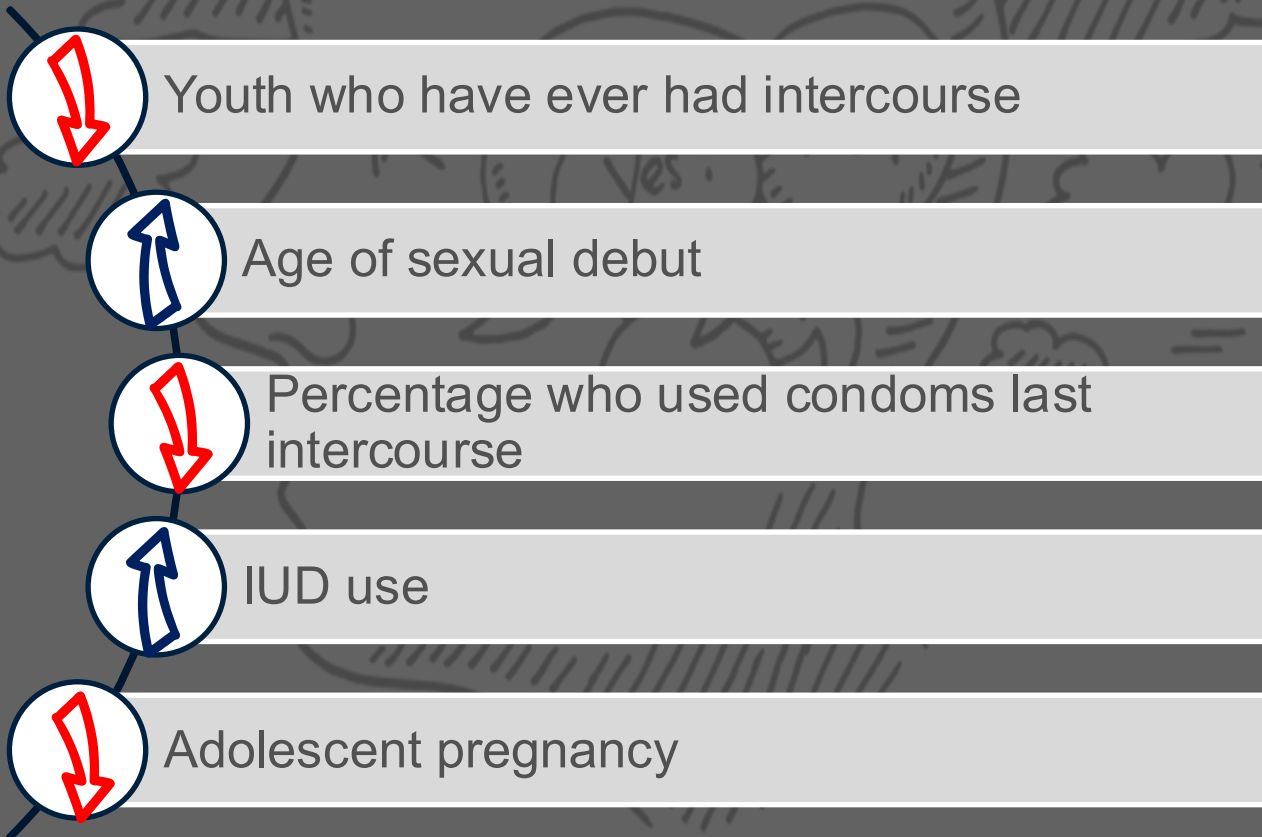
Method used to prevent pregnancy the last time they had intercourse (among youth who ever had intercourse)				
	2008	2013	2018	2023
Condoms	64%	64%	58%	53%
Withdrawal	23%	35%	46%	39%
Birth control pills, birth control patch, vaginal ring, or other method prescribed by doctor or nurse	NA	NA	44%	31%
Emergency contraception	5%	6%	7%	10%
IUD	1%	NA	3%	7%
Depo Provera	2%	2%	2%	1%
Not sure	3%	3%	3%	5%
No method	6%	3%	2%	3%

- Canadian teen pregnancy rates declined 37.2% from 1990-2010 (McKay 2012)



KIDS THESE DAYS

BC Adolescent Health Survey
1992-2023



A few more things about youth & adolescents...

- Youth in the 21st century are often labeled as part of “hook up culture” (sexual engagement with no/little commitment). However, most Canadian relationships among youth are ongoing and monogamous (15% deemed ‘experimenters’ and 85% ‘non-experimenters’ in 2010 Netting)
- “Younger teens tend to have more sexual partners in the first year they have sex than older teens. That means that if someone is 14-15 years old when they become sexually active, they are more likely to have three or more sexual partners that year, than if someone is 16-17 years old when they start having sex.” SARAVYC
- Young women who engage in casual sex are judged more harshly than young men (protective: confidence, higher SE class)
- 88% of males and 68% of females identified themselves as “completely straight” (AHS 2023)



20% of youth had ever had sexual intercourse, which was a decrease from ten years ago (22%).

Did You Know?

The 2018 BC Adolescent Health Survey, completed by over 38,000 of the province's young people in Grades 7-12 showed that:

Most youth felt they were able to say no if they were asked to engage in a sexual activity they did not want to take part in. Younger youth were more likely than older ones to think they would be able to say no.

Among youth who had ever had sex, the most common age for first doing so was 15 or 16 years old.

1% of youth had been told by a doctor or nurse that they had an STI.

22% of students who ever had sexual intercourse used alcohol or drugs before they had sex the last time.

Among youth who had intercourse, 46% used withdrawal to prevent pregnancy, and 10% used it as their only contraceptive method (an increase from 6% in 2008).

63% of youth who ever had intercourse used a condom or other protection the last time they had sex.

5% of youth with a phone used it on their most recent school day to engage in sexting and 12% used it to watch pornography.

1% of youth had ever been pregnant or got someone pregnant.



Illustration and art design by Alex van der Merwe

Sexual health information and BC-based resources:

optionsforsexualhealth.org

scarleteen.com

Inclusive sexuality and relationships information for teens and young adults

smartsexresource.com

Online chat with a nurse

youthinbc.com

Online chat with a crisis responder from 12:00pm - 1:00am daily

ppt.on.ca/education/facts/

Offers factsheets on birth control options, STIs, sexual pleasure and related issues.



McCreary
Centre Society

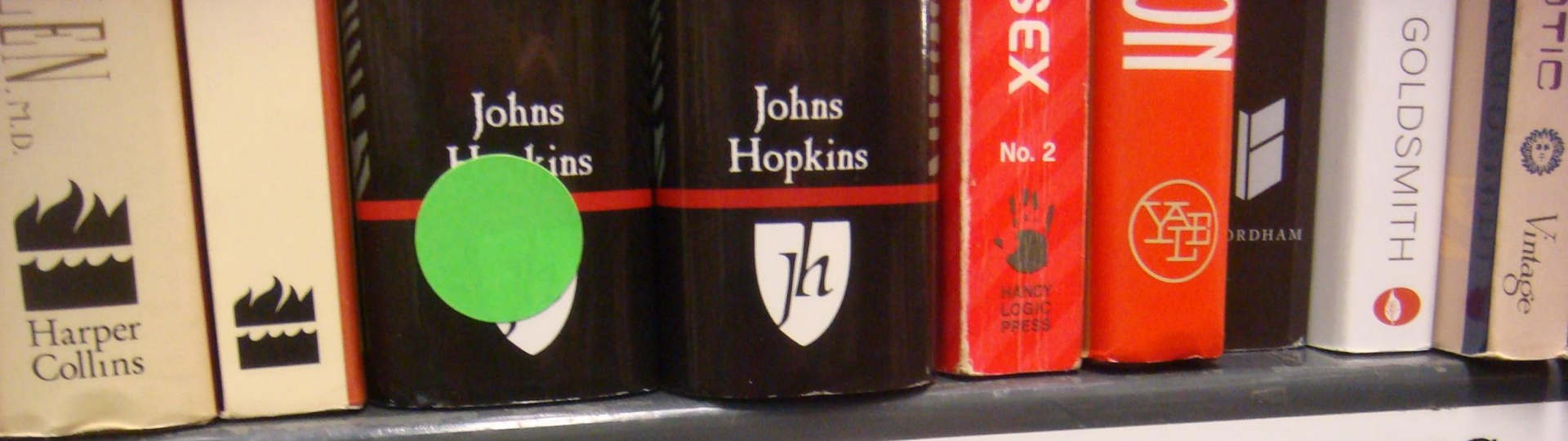


SCARLETEEN

sex ed for the real world

inclusive, comprehensive, supportive
SEXUALITY and RELATIONSHIPS
info for teens and emerging adults





SEXUALITY CONTINUES



THE UNIVERSITY OF BRITISH COLUMBIA

